

Historical and Cultural Context of Headley Farm (Calhoun County, Alabama)

Origins of the Headley Farm House (c.1832)

The farmhouse at Headley Farm is reportedly built in 1832, making it a rare survivor from Alabama's early statehood period . This was just after the Creek Indians ceded the land that became Calhoun County to the United States, so the house likely began as a frontier homestead on newly opened territory . Its original builder is not definitively documented, but it was probably an early settler capitalizing on the 1832 land lottery and sales. The architecture would have been practical and vernacular – perhaps a one-story log or timber frame structure with multiple fireplaces for heat – later adapted with new materials (the house today has modern siding over its old bones). Local lore even claims the house served as a speakeasy during Prohibition, catering to soldiers from nearby Fort McClellan in the 1920s. While concrete evidence of a speakeasy at the farm is scarce, the tale is plausible: Anniston was officially dry, yet clandestine bars flourished (the historic Peerless Saloon downtown, for example, covertly operated a speakeasy on its second floor during that era). These anecdotes add color to the farm's history – suggesting that beyond its humble agrarian origins, the old house was a silent witness to jazz-age revelry when alcohol was outlawed.

Over the decades, the Headley Farm house would have seen many chapters of local history. It stood through the Civil War years (1861–65) as an antebellum structure, likely sheltering families or serving as a waystation in a county that, while not a major battlefield, experienced its share of wartime hardship. In the early 20th century, with Fort McClellan established next door, the farm's proximity to the base tied it into the social life of soldiers and civilians. By the time of World War II, when Fort McClellan swelled with troops, the old farmhouse was already well over a century old – a familiar landmark on the landscape. Through it all, the building's enduring presence (and the stories attached to it) has made Headley Farm a piece of living history in Calhoun County. Preserving this 1832 house today means more than saving wood and nails; it means safeguarding a tangible

connection to the region's frontier days, its roaring '20s secrets, and the many generations who have passed under its roof.

Chief Ladiga and the Muscogee (Creek) Land Cessions

Long before Alabama statehood, the land that includes Headley Farm was Muscogee Creek territory. Chief Ladiga (also spelled "Laydiga" or "LeHoagg") was a local Creek leader whose fate became entwined with this land's transition to American hands. In March 1832, Ladiga was among the chiefs who signed the Treaty of Cusseta, an agreement by which the Creek Nation ceded all remaining claims to land in east Alabama . This treaty was part of President Andrew Jackson's broader Indian Removal policy, coming on the heels of laws that Alabama passed to extend state jurisdiction over Creek lands and force the issue of removal or assimilation . Under the Cusseta Treaty, Creek chiefs and heads-of-family could retain individual allotments of land (generally 640 acres for a chief) in Alabama, even as the rest was surrendered to the U.S. . Ladiga took such an allotment in what was then Benton County (now Calhoun County).

Because he signed the treaty, Ladiga was allowed to select a reservation of land for his wife and himself in this area . Just a year later, in 1833, he decided to sell a portion of his holdings. For the sum of \$2,000, Ladiga sold about half of his land to a group of speculators led by an early settler named Charles White Peters . On July 20, 1833, that tract was used to found the town of Jacksonville (originally called "Drayton" before being renamed to honor Andrew Jackson) . Thus, Jacksonville – which today lies only a few miles from Headley Farm – quite literally sits on land that once belonged to Chief Ladiga. This remarkable fact is documented in local histories: the town purchased its site from "Creek Indian Chief 'Du-Hoag' Ladiga" in 1833 . Jacksonville became the first county seat of Benton (Calhoun) County, and one of the earliest American towns in the former Creek domain.

After the sale, Chief Ladiga and his family moved westward. They settled among the Cherokee (perhaps his wife's people) near what is now Piedmont, Alabama . Ladiga's cabin in Piedmont reportedly stood until around 1900, and he was buried in that vicinity, so his grave rests in Calhoun County soil . His personal story is a window into the broader Muscogee presence and displacement in this region. The Creeks had lived in east Alabama for generations – farming, hunting, and maintaining villages – and Chief Ladiga was an influential headman of the Upper

Creeks. But encroachment by American settlers and pressure from state and federal authorities led to successive cessions of Creek territory: notably the 1814 Treaty of Fort Jackson (after the Red Stick War) and then the final cession via the Treaty of Cusseta in 1832 . Alabama even created eight new counties (including Benton County) out of the ceded lands by late 1832 . Creeks who tried to stay often faced harassment; tensions culminated in the “Second Creek War” of 1836, which resulted in the forced removal of most remaining Creeks to Indian Territory.

Chief Ladiga’s land transfer is one of the best-remembered episodes of this fraught period in Calhoun County. It illustrates how Native leaders negotiated the twilight of their autonomy – some, like Ladiga, secured land (at least briefly) and even profited by selling to the incoming Americans, thereby smoothing the transition for the establishment of new towns and farms. Surviving documentation of these transactions includes deeds and legislative records: for example, the Alabama legislature’s act on December 18, 1832 formally created Benton County from the Creek cession , and Jacksonville’s founding is recorded in deeds dated 1833. Today, Chief Ladiga’s legacy lives on in local place names – most prominently the Chief Ladiga Trail, a 33-mile rail-trail for biking and hiking that runs through Calhoun County. The trail’s name honors Ladiga’s role in regional history and reminds us that the soil beneath our feet was once Creek land . Any heritage interpretation of Headley Farm should include this context: the farm exists on former Muscogee land, obtained through a treaty that Ladiga and others signed under great duress. By telling the story of Ladiga and the Creeks – their culture, the loss of their homeland, and the founding of Jacksonville – we frame Headley Farm not just as an old white homestead, but as a site layered with Native American history and the epochal changes of the 1830s.

Fort McClellan: From Establishment to Prohibition-Era Lore and Beyond

Buckner Hall at Fort McClellan, built in the 1930s in Spanish Colonial Revival style. Fort McClellan’s elegant design earned it a reputation as the “military showplace of the South,” blending functionality with beauty .

Fort McClellan’s development deeply influenced the culture and economy of Calhoun County – and by proximity, places like Headley Farm. The Fort’s story began amid the World War I mobilization. In April 1917, as the United States entered WWI, the Army selected an area adjacent to Anniston for a training camp due to its rail connections and suitable terrain . By July 1917, “Camp McClellan”

was officially established, named after Civil War General George B. McClellan . The Army rapidly built a huge tent city and wooden barracks to house and train soldiers. Although WWI ended in 1918, the camp had already made its mark: about 27,000 troops trained there, and it brought a surge of activity to what had been rural land. The camp was put on caretaker status after the war, but locals lobbied to keep a permanent post. In 1929, those efforts paid off – the War Department upgraded Camp McClellan to Fort McClellan, a permanent garrison installation for an infantry regiment . During the 1930s, New Deal investments (including WPA funds) allowed the construction of enduring structures – headquarters, officers’ quarters, a hospital, a theater, and more – often in a handsome Spanish Colonial Revival style with stucco walls and red tile roofs . This building campaign gave Fort McClellan an architectural cohesion and charm uncommon for Army bases.

By the late 1930s and into World War II, Fort McClellan expanded massively. It became one of the largest U.S. Army training installations during WWII, ultimately training an estimated half a million troops for service . The base’s footprint sprawled over the Choccolocco foothills, with dozens of miles of roads, its own huge hospital complex, theaters, ranges, and housing for tens of thousands of soldiers . Virtually every branch of the Army used McClellan at some point – infantry divisions did basic training here, and units staged for deployment overseas. The fort also held Italian and German POWs during WWII, and even they left a cultural trace (German prisoners famously painted murals inside Remington Hall while interned, for example). During these peak years, Fort McClellan was like a city within a city, and Anniston’s population and businesses grew in tandem. The fort’s presence meant jobs for civilians, contracts for local suppliers, and a constant interaction between soldiers and the community. Fort McClellan trainees and personnel became part of local lore; for generations, nearly every family in Calhoun County had someone who worked at the fort or a story of a soldier they befriended. Indeed, “for more than eighty years [Fort McClellan] was an integral part of the economy and the community character of the City of Anniston” .

Troops from McClellan fought in every American conflict of the 20th century through the 1990s, carrying a bit of Alabama with them around the world .

One colorful chapter of Fort McClellan’s history (and one that ties back to Headley Farm’s lore) is the Prohibition era (1920–1933). In the 1920s, when alcohol was outlawed nationally, Fort McClellan was a smaller post (between wars) but still active with a garrison and summer training camps. The soldiers, like local civilians,

often sought illicit drink and entertainment. Speakeasies and bootleggers popped up around Anniston to meet that demand. It's easy to imagine off-duty troops slipping out to rural hideaways for a taste of moonshine or home-brew. Headley Farm's alleged speakeasy arose in this context. Being just a few miles from the fort, down country lanes hidden by pines, it would have been an ideal spot for a secret tavern – close enough for the enlisted men to reach, but far enough from town to avoid prying eyes. While no official records pin the farmhouse to a specific raid or incident, we do know that speakeasy culture thrived in the region despite the law. For example, downtown Anniston's Peerless Saloon (opened 1899) simply moved its liquor trade underground when Prohibition hit; its upstairs became a concealed nightclub and brothel until repeal . On base, the Army strictly forbade alcohol, but enforcement was a cat-and-mouse game. Fort McClellan trainees likely learned to rely on friendly locals for a clandestine drink. Oral histories from old-timers in Calhoun County often mention hidden stills in the hills and dance halls operating "in the dry." Thus, the story of a speakeasy at the Headley house – if true – fits perfectly into the fort's cultural footprint of that era. It highlights the mingling of military and local life: young men in uniform blowing off steam in the countryside, and a resourceful farmhouse owner turning a profit by bending the rules.

After WWII, Fort McClellan's role evolved. Though it was placed on inactive status for a brief period in 1947, the dawn of the Cold War brought it back to life as a vital training center . From 1950 onward, Fort McClellan hosted two major Army schools: the Chemical Corps School (training in chemical/biological/radiological defense) and the **Military Police School** . It also was home to the Women's Army Corps (WAC) training center – in fact, Fort McClellan was the primary base for training female Army recruits and officers from the late 1940s until the WAC was integrated into the regular Army in 1978 . The influx of thousands of female soldiers was a unique cultural element – local residents still recall the sight of marching WACs and the new perspectives these women brought to the area. By the 1970s–90s, Fort McClellan was like a self-contained town with supermarkets, churches, and schools for Army families. At its height, the post housed about 10,000 military personnel and 1,500 civilian employees on any given day . The soldiers trained there not only spent money in the local economy but many settled permanently, marrying locals or retiring in Anniston. This created a diverse community of folks with ties to all corners of the country. The base's closure in

1999 under the BRAC (Base Realignment and Closure) program was economically and emotionally impactful – truly the “end of an era” for Calhoun County. Fort McClellan had operated for 82 years (1917–1999) continuously . Since then, parts of the property have been redeveloped (a mixed-use community and an industrial park now occupy some former training areas), while a portion remains under the Alabama National Guard. The legacy of the fort, however, endures in local memory and in the continued presence of facilities like the Anniston Army Depot nearby. For the Headley Farm narrative, Fort McClellan provides a rich backdrop: from the post’s founding when the farmhouse was already old, through the rambunctious Prohibition days, to the wartime boom that surely shook the quiet countryside with the rumble of artillery practice. Emphasizing this military connection – perhaps with anecdotes of G.I.’s knocking on the farmhouse door in search of supper or spirits – can really bring the site’s history to life. It shows how a single place can be tied into national history: Indian removal, frontier settlement, and the U.S. Army at war and peace.

Preservation and Heritage Opportunities for Headley Farm

Given its deep historical roots, Headley Farm is an excellent candidate for historic preservation and heritage development. Owners of such a property in Alabama have several programs, grants, and incentives available to help preserve and share its story:

- Alabama Historical Commission Grants: The Alabama Historical Commission (AHC) administers an annual state-funded grant program for historic sites. Notably, pre-1840 structures that are publicly accessible or owned by nonprofits are given top priority . As a house purportedly built in 1832, the Headley Farm home squarely meets this preferred criterion. AHC grants can provide funds (up to \$75,000 per grant) for preservation work – for example, stabilizing the structure, restoring historic features, or developing educational exhibits . To qualify, one typically needs the site to be listed on or eligible for the National Register of Historic Places, and ideally have a plan for public engagement (such as occasional tours or events). Headley Farm could partner with a local historical society or even the county government to apply, if the current owners are private individuals. Securing an AHC grant would not only bring funding but also prestige and credibility to the project.

- **National Register of Historic Places:** Pursuing a National Register listing is highly recommended. Listing doesn't impose restrictions on private owners, but it formally recognizes the property's historical significance. This recognition opens doors to incentives like rehabilitation tax credits. Alabama offers a 25% state historic tax credit for approved restoration expenses on historic homes (available to both private residential owners and commercial owners) . For example, if owners spent money to restore the 1832 house's original wood siding or heart-pine floors, 25% of those costs could be credited back on Alabama income taxes – a substantial financial boost. Coupled with that, National Register listing also qualifies a property for an ad valorem tax break: Alabama law allows historic properties on the Register to be assessed for property tax at a lower rate (10% of value rather than 20%), significantly reducing annual property taxes . Additionally, income-producing uses of the property (say, if part of it becomes a bed-and-breakfast or event venue) could tap the Federal 20% Rehabilitation Tax Credit on the cost of restoring the building, provided work follows preservation standards . In short, getting Headley Farm listed as a historic place provides both honor and tangible benefits. The process involves preparing a nomination with the farm's history, architecture, and significance (all the topics discussed above would go into that document).
- **Targeted Heritage Grants:** Because Headley Farm's story intersects with Native American history, early Alabama statehood, and military history, it can qualify for various niche grants or partnerships. For Native American heritage: while most grants in this realm go directly to tribes, one approach is to collaborate with the Muscogee (Creek) Nation or the Poarch Band of Creek Indians (the federally recognized tribes related to the Creek legacy in Alabama). They might support or advise on interpretive signage about Chief Ladiga and the Creek people. There are also federal grants like the NPS "Tribal Heritage Grants" (which tribes must apply for) that fund the preservation of sites affiliated with Native history – a tribe might be interested in jointly promoting the story of Ladiga's land if asked. For early statehood/frontier history, Alabama recently celebrated its bicentennial (1819–2019) with grants, and though that specific program has ended, the Alabama Humanities Alliance often funds projects that involve public history and storytelling. A well-crafted proposal for an exhibit or oral history project about the farm (e.g. "From Creek

Land to Settler Farm: The Headley Farm Story") could attract a humanities grant . As for military history, one resource is the Legacy Resource Management Program (through the Department of Defense) which sometimes funds preservation of historic military sites – though usually on former base property, so Headley Farm might not qualify directly. However, local veteran organizations or Army museums might lend support. For instance, the Anniston Museum of Natural History and Berman Museum have shown interest in regional history; perhaps they'd partner on a Fort McClellan/Prohibition exhibit if the farm has artifacts or stories to contribute.

- Local and Private Funding: Alabama is fortunate to have some strong private foundations and heritage organizations. The Alabama Trust for Historic Preservation maintains a list of preservation funding opportunities . Two prominent statewide foundations to note are the Alabama Power Foundation and the Daniel Foundation of Alabama, which both fund community and cultural projects . The Alabama Power Foundation, for example, has a grants category for "strengthening communities" and "promoting arts and culture," under which a historic farm restoration with an educational mission could fit . The Daniel Foundation similarly supports projects in historic preservation as part of civic improvement . A strategy for Headley Farm could be to set up a nonprofit friends group or trust specifically for the property, which can then apply to these foundations for assistance – perhaps to create a small museum area in the house, or to host heritage events (imagine an annual Creek Heritage Day or a Fort McClellan Living History weekend on the farm). On the local level, the Calhoun County Commission and the City of Anniston have been known to support heritage tourism efforts – since Chief Ladiga and Fort McClellan are key themes in local history, those entities might have tourism grants or could help with marketing once the site is visitor-ready. Don't overlook crowdfunding and community fundraising either: the layered story of this farm (Native American roots, pioneer home, speakeasy legend, military neighbor) makes it a compelling narrative to pitch on platforms like GoFundMe or Kickstarter, especially if funds will go toward an educational cause. Storytelling will be your ally here – engaging the public's imagination about what the walls of the old house have "seen" can inspire donations.

In terms of heritage framing, it will be beneficial to interpret Headley Farm as a microcosm of Alabama history. By presenting the property as "where cultures

crossed” – Creek and American – and “where old traditions met new” – a farm that went from plowshares to secret whiskey stills when duty called – you create a hook for both grants and tourism. For example, a heritage brochure or display might read: “Headley Farm: Established 1832 on the land of Chief Ladiga, this homestead grew with Alabama – from a Creek Indian frontier to a cotton plantation, from Civil War hardship to the jazz and secret stills of Prohibition, and on through World War II as Fort McClellan’s quiet neighbor.” Such framing hits multiple themes that funders care about: Native American heritage, early settlement, and 20th-century military history.

To summarize the opportunities: Headley Farm can seek state grants aimed at sites as old and significant as this one ; leverage tax incentives to ease the financial burden of restoration ; and pursue partnerships or grants focused on its unique blend of cultural history. By doing so, the stewards of Headley Farm will not only preserve a valuable landmark but also create a rich educational resource for Calhoun County and Alabama. The end goal could be a kind of living history farm or museum, or even a heritage bed-and-breakfast that lets guests “step back in time.” In fundraising applications and grant proposals, be sure to cite the documented historical facts (like the 1833 Jacksonville land purchase from Ladiga or the Prohibition-era anecdotes) with sources, as we’ve done here, to show that the site’s story is well-researched and authentic. With an engaging story and solid plans, Headley Farm stands to benefit from the growing interest in preserving places that connect us to our complex past. Each log, brick, and floorboard has a tale to tell – and with support from preservation programs, we can ensure those tales continue to be told for generations to come.

Sources:

- Encyclopedia of Alabama – Treaty of Cusseta (1832) ; Calhoun County (creation of Benton County in 1832) .
- Jacksonville, AL history – land purchased from Chief Ladiga in 1833 .
- Chief Ladiga Trail info – Ladiga’s land selection and sale of Jacksonville .
- Fort McClellan history – Wikipedia and Anniston city documents (established 1917, WWII peak, closed 1999) ; design and role in community .
- Peerless Saloon NRHP Listing – description of upstairs speakeasy/brothel during Prohibition .

- Alabama Historical Commission grant guidelines (2025) .
- Alabama historic tax credit program – 25% credit for NR-listed homes .
- Alabama Trust for Historic Preservation – list of funding sources including Alabama Power Foundation and Daniel Foundation .
- Property data for 5400 Ridgewood Ave (Headley Farm house) – built in 1832 .